

Octane Software Solutions - Discovery scripts & Guidelines

1. Discovery Pre-Screen Framework

All discovery calls are 30 minutes in length and aim to qualify prospects across three distinct tracks (Variants) based on their current technology stack and business interests.

2. Variant A: First-Time TM1 / Planning Analytics Users

Targeting prospects who consolidate financial data manually in Excel spreadsheets and do not have a dedicated multi-dimensional database.

Questions & Guidance:

1. **ERP Integration:** What general ledger/ERP system (e.g., SAP, MS Business Central, NetSuite) are you using, and does it currently integrate with your planning tool?
2. **Spreadsheets Count:** How many separate Excel spreadsheets are you manually consolidating for your budgeting and forecasting, and are there issues with version control?
3. **Planning Workflows:** What specific planning workflows (e.g., actuals, payroll allocations, cost analysis, budgeting, forecasting) are you executing, and are allocations inconsistent or time-consuming?
4. **Reporting Stack:** What reporting tools (e.g., Power BI, Qlik, Tableau, Excel PAX/PAW) do you use for management reporting, and do you manually export CSV files to reconcile data?
5. **Drill Down Capability:** Do users need to drill down from high-level reports to transaction-level GL data, and do you perform multi-currency transactions?
6. **Admin Staffing:** Do you have internal developers/admins to manage these systems, or is there a key-person risk if someone leaves?
7. **User Counts:** How many planning contributors, read-only users, and administrators are involved, and would they need formal training?
8. **Repetitive Operations:** What repetitive financial tasks feel most manual, and would conversational AI access to financial queries benefit your executives?
9. **Timeline:** What is your target timeline for going live, and do you need a parallel run (e.g., completing by a specific month like June)?
10. **Budget Framework:** Is there a budget allocated for licensing and delivery, and what is your internal approval/purchase order process?
11. **Tool Evaluation:** Have you evaluated other tools (e.g. Workday, Anaplan, TM1), and who else is involved in the final decision?
12. **Success Criteria:** What does success look like, and would a 60-day trial of connectors (like DataFusion) or a free Proof of Concept (POC) help validate the solution?

3. Variant B: Existing TM1 / Planning Analytics Users

Targeting prospects who already run an instance of IBM Planning Analytics / TM1 but face support bottlenecks, performance issues, or require upgrades.

Questions & Guidance:

1. **Version & Deployment:** What version of TM1/Planning Analytics are you running, and is it deployed on-premise or in the IBM Cloud?
2. **Instance Count:** How many TM1 instances do you run (e.g., production-only, or separate dev and test environments)?
3. **Model Scale:** How many models, cubes, dimensions, and user groups are you currently running?
4. **Performance Metrics:** Have you checked your system's performance, RAM usage, hard disk space, or feeder memory usage? Are they approaching high limits?
5. **Log File Size:** Are log files being automatically cleared, and what is the typical size of your TM1 log files (e.g., is it under or over the 50MB standard)?
6. **Report Load Times:** What are the typical report load times for your end-users, and are they above the 5-second threshold?
7. **Team Staffing:** Do you have dedicated in-house TM1 administrators/developers, or are you dependent on key individuals?
8. **Vendor Lock-in:** Are you currently working with another TM1 vendor? Are you locked into a rigid contract with separate rates for support and development?
9. **Backlog Scale:** What is your current backlog of enhancements, bugs, or data reconciliation tasks, and how is it prioritized?
10. **Training Portals:** Have your TM1 developers and power users had formal training, and would they benefit from free access to professional training courses?
11. **Reporting Integration:** Are you using Power BI, Tableau, or Qlik, and do you have a direct database connection or are you manually handling CSVs?
12. **Approval Timeline:** Who has final authority to approve support changes, and what is the timeline to transition support (e.g. target date like October 31)?

4. Variant C: First-Time Generative AI Users

Targeting enterprise prospects who want to automate workflows or integrate AI agent networks across their business units.

Questions & Guidance:

1. **Reporting Bottlenecks:** How many slides are in your monthly executive financial reports, and how much time does the finance team spend manually extracting, cleansing, and formatting data for them?
2. **Data Source Matrix:** What enterprise systems and data sources (e.g., TM1, Adobe Analytics, Google Ad Manager, Adobe AdSlot, BigQuery, SQL) need to connect for automated reporting?
3. **Natural Language Queries:** Would executives and managers benefit from asking natural language questions (e.g. "AskFinance") to query financial data in real time?
4. **Operational Repetition:** What other areas in the business (e.g. Sales, Editorial, HR, Customer Support, IT, Procurement, Legal) have repetitive workflows ripe for automation?
5. **AI Exposure:** Have you experimented with or deployed any generative AI or automation tools internally?
6. **Cloud Stack:** What is your primary cloud environment (e.g. GCP, AWS, Azure, on-premise) and how do you manage data security?
7. **Access Control:** Do you require specific role-based access controls and security protocols for financial data queried by AI?

8. ****Co-Creation POC:**** Would you be open to a 2-to-6 week co-creation Proof of Concept (POC) to demonstrate value before full production rollout?
9. ****Resource Commitment:**** Can you commit a primary business contact and technical resource to collaborate during a 2-to-6 week POC?
10. ****Decision Timelines:**** Are you willing to commit to a Decision Workshop within 10 days of POC completion to confirm next steps?
11. ****Budget Awareness:**** Are you aware of the indicative costs for enterprise generative AI licensing (\$160k+/yr) and implementation services (\$125k+)?
12. ****Stakeholders:**** What is your timeline for starting an AI pilot, and who are the key executive stakeholders involved?